

Excerpt from “Linguistic Sludge and the Postmodern Black Identity” for English Senior Seminar

Criticism and analysis of postmodern theatre is abundant, yet very little criticism exists on postmodern Black theatre. This is certainly not due to a lack of postmodern Black plays. Suzan-Lori Parks, a contemporary Black playwright, is responsible for some of the most influential plays of contemporary American theatre. *Topdog/Underdog* (2002) is her most successful work. The play has been referred to as the “homeboy Godot,” comparing it to Samuel Beckett’s *Waiting for Godot*, which is part of the postmodern movement of the Theatre of the Absurd. Parks’ *The Red Letter Plays*, including *In The Blood* (1999) and *Fucking A* (2000), use music and Nathaniel Hawthorne’s *The Scarlet Letter* to depict Black identity in a dystopian, postmodern society. Parks’ plays exist comfortably within the postmodern genre because they extend the questions raised in earlier Black theatre with a postmodern approach. *Mule Bone: A Comedy of Negro Life* (1931), by Langston Hughes and Zora Neale Hurston, and *A Raisin in the Sun* (1959), by Lorraine Hansberry, explore Black identity in 20th century America. Each explores the identity of male and female characters who desire to function outside of the traditional Black roles: men as hard laborers and women as sexual objects for reproduction. These traditional identities, created through slavery, exploit the Black body.

All four plays rely on language to depict the characters’ search for new identities that allow them to escape exploitation and oppression. However, the language is reliant on the spatial and temporal setting of each play. In the early plays, the language *is specific to* the setting, signifying clear meaning. In Parks’ plays, the language *can only exist* within the settings of each play, signifying ambiguous meaning. Suzan-Lori Parks extends the search for identity present in *Mule Bone* and *A Raisin in the Sun*, but utilizes language differently, focusing on the signifier of the language itself rather than the signified meaning. Language in the postmodern plays

Topdog/Underdog and *Fucking A* does not simply exist within the liminal temporal and spatial displacement of the settings, but functions as a signifier of a character's identity.

[...]

The intertextual characters borrowed from fiction and history become signifiers that can only exist within the spatial and temporal displacement of *Topdog*. By excluding any specificity of setting, the characters are removed from their fictional and historical context, placing a greater focus on the signifier of the character. In *Topdog*, Parks uses the setting: "Place: Here, Time: Now." (*Topdog* 7). By using these terms, Parks is creating a time and place that are both vague and dislocated. *Topdog's* action takes place in Booth and Lincoln's "seedily furnished rooming house room," which is in an unspecified urban location (11). As McHale explains, the liminal space is relocated from the periphery in Modernism to the center of these urban cities in Postmodernism (50). These liminal spaces resemble the "grim dystopias" which are common in Postmodernism (McHale 67).

Similarly, *Fucking A's* setting is also ambiguous and contradictory. Parks includes in a note stating "the setting should be spare and reflect the poverty of the world of the play" but does not locate the poor space (*Fucking A* 115). A few scenes take place by the sea; the stage directions state "A park bench in the middle of nowhere overlooking the sea" (137). This note gives the setting a strange discontinuity-- park benches are rarely in the middle of nowhere. Additionally, the First Lady refers to the Mayor's "small town," but later the Mayor states that his taking a new wife would be "for the good of the country" (152). The contradictory poor space is both a town and a country, but nothing else is given other than that *Europe* (always italicized in the script) is far away. Like her use of space and time in *Topdog*, Parks displaces the action in a vague, liminal space at the center of a larger space.

The liminal, vague spaces of *Topdog* and *Fucking A* allow for the existence of unique language. Parks retains the use of the Black vernacular present in *Mule* and *Raisin*, but adds jargon in *Topdog* and patois in *Fucking A*. This “linguistic sludge,” could be considered “lexical exhibitionism” (McHale 152). The meaning of the words, or the linguistic signified, is less important than the presence language itself. Parks draws the actor’s attention to the unconventional nature of her dialogue with her explanation of her “Elements of Style.” (*Topdog* 5). Both scripts have what Parks refers to as “Spells,” or “an elongated and heightened” pause without dialogue. They appear on the page as:

LINCOLN.	Reverend D.
BOOTH.	Hester.
LINCOLN.	Reverend D.
BOOTH. (<i>Topdog</i> 5).	Hester. (<i>Fucking A</i> ix).

Parks explains: “This is a place where the characters experience their pure true simple state. While no action or stage business is necessary, directors should fill this moment as they best see fit.” (*Topdog* 5). This style requires an explanation to the actor because it does not follow conventional script formatting. Parks’ style is a postmodern example of communicating to the actors. Parks is acutely aware of the meaning conveyed through space occupied by the words on the page, which McHale refers to as “spatialized language” (56). Although an audience member would not be aware of this technique, by spatializing the silences on the page for the actors, Parks is placing emphasis on the signifiers of the pauses and the dialogue around them. Parks writes the dialogue is unconventionally, with misspelling words and omitting commas and apostrophes. The spatialized nature of the unconventional dialogue raises the importance of the language itself, rather than the linguistic meaning.

In *Topdog*, Booth and Lincoln use a patter when dealing 3-card monte. Booth mutters “who-see-thuh-red-card-who-see-thuh-red-card? I-see-thuh-red-card. The-red-card-is-thuh-

winner” as he pretends to be throwing 3-card monte (*Topdog* 11). The stage directions describe “His moves and accompanying patter are, for the most part, studied and awkward” (11). In the final scene of the play, Lincoln agrees to show Booth how to deal 3-card monte like he used to. His patter and movements are “fluid, expert, and natural,” demonstrating his greater skill as the Topdog (78). The mastery of this jargon directly relates to 3-card monte skill.

In *Fucking A*, Hester and the other women use TALK, a patois language that resembles English and Swahili, in conversation about the female body and abortion. Examples include, “die Abah-nazip” meaning “The abortion” (*Fucking A* 117, 223) and “Meh Kazo-say greengrass ee-sunny skies ee” meaning “nice and pleasant vagina” (128, 223). The Second Hunter, one of the few men who speak TALK, speaks “Just enough to get by” (146). The First Hunter responds saying that his wife wanted him to learn TALK as well, but he refused, saying “Keep that stuff private. Like it should be” (146). TALK signifies private, female body conversation as well as a certain knowledge that the men do not possess. However, while the women possess this special language, they are unable to read or write. Hester must go to a Scribe to write to her son in prison; the Butcher must read a letter to Canary. By being illiterate, Hester remains a liminal figure, despite her specialized knowledge of the female body signified by TALK.

The Author's Note states that “The production should present a nonaudible simultaneous English translation” (*Fucking A* 115). This glossing of terms is a trait of Postmodernism, described by McHale as creating “two parallel texts” that force the audience to split their attention, slightly removing them from the action (191). By translating TALK, the audience does not have to determine the meaning of the words, but can instead focus on the presence of the language itself. The use of TALK in *Fucking A* is placing more focus on the signifier of the language and less on the meaning of the words. Patter and TALK are examples of the signifier

being promoted over the signified linguistic meaning. However, while ambiguous in meaning, these linguistic signifiers are very clear in function. TALK and Patter both exhibit the speaker's knowledge of a criminal or morally reprehensible occupation.

Expanding of the question of identity in earlier Black theatre, Parks suggests that if the Black characters reject traditional exploitative roles, their only other option is a liminal, morally reprehensible function: crime for men with 3-card monte and immorality for women with abortion. In *Fucking A*, Hester's chest is branded with an "A" for abortionist, which is visible through a square hole in her dress: "The brand comes with the job is all I know. 'And the brand must be visible at all times.' That's the law" (*Fucking A* 164). The wound "weeps" when a customer is at her door (25). The other characters also refer to its offensive odor, signifying the shameful nature of being an abortionist. Her "A" is a mark of shame, but she also explains that it is her "license" (165). Hester's occupation is not criminal, as 3-card monte *Topdog*, but it is despicable and shameful. She does not tell her son she is an abortionist so he won't be "shamed cause his mother is a babykiller" (148). Her occupation is clearly recognized and permitted by the government, so therefore she is not a criminal. However, the shameful nature of her occupation places her in a liminal position. Canary, a prostitute, states that "No one would wanna kill you. We need you too much. Like me, you perform one of those disresponsible but most necessary services" (121). Hester acknowledges the moral ambiguity of her role as well when speaking to the Butcher: "What we do is bad. And good. And bad and good and good and bad. There's no easy way to look at it" (165). She continues by explaining that she had no choice: "Go to prison or take this job. That was my choice" (165). Although she was forced into the job, Hester fulfills a necessary role. Hester has escaped her role as a sexual object, yet she is still trapped in a liminal role necessary to society's reproduction as terminator of unwanted life.

In *Topdog*, Booth, Lincoln's younger brother, wants to learn to be a 3-card monte dealer. Lincoln was once a successful dealer, but quit dealing after his friend Lonny was shot. Lincoln is now a President Lincoln impersonator in an arcade, where “They pay [him] less than theyd pay a white guy” (*Topdog* 34). Lincoln refers to this as “honest work,” unlike dealing 3-card monte which he refuses to return to (27). Lincoln's “honest” job is still oppressive because he is paid less than a white man and is forced to reenact death repeatedly. Booth's function is one of a criminal. He shoplifts most things he owns and desires to become a 3-card monte dealer – a simple thief. Though Lincoln and Booth have escaped hard laborer, they are still trapped in liminal, exploitative roles that end in death. Hester, Lincoln, and Booth's functions, though not exploiting the body, remain as oppressive as the traditional Black identities. The characters are unable to function fully in society and are forced into criminal or shameful roles that result in death.

Parks' use of intertextual historical and fictional characters foreshadow the imminent deaths from the beginning of the plays. In the end, the audience is desensitized to the death, because they have been expecting it. Death is not problematic, but useful for these postmodern texts as signifiers of the consequences of liminal identities. In the last scene of *Topdog*, Lincoln wins Booth's \$500 inheritance, which his mother left him many years ago. Booth becomes very angry and shoots Lincoln, providing the expected and inevitable ending to the play. Initially Booth taunts Lincoln's dead body saying “You aint gonna be needing yr fucking money-roll no more, dead motherfucker” (114). He then collapses and “holds Lincolns body, hugging him close” screaming “AAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAH!” while sobbing (115). This ending depicts not only the expected death of Lincoln, but Booth's violence as the result of 3-card monte.

The final scene of *Fucking A*, Hester slits her son's throat. Hester's son, Monster, has been imprisoned for over 30 years. He has collected many convictions: "Murder, necrophilia, sodomy, bestiality, pedophilia, armed robbery, petty theft, embezzlement, diddling in public, cannibalism" (*Fucking A* 143). In the world of the play "where more are in prison than free," there seems to be many laws, but there is also anarchy (133). The Butcher lists his daughter LuLu's long list of crimes including "Prostitution [...] claiming to have injuries she didn't have, claiming to be places she never was, [...] hanging upside down in public, [...] fornicating with the Other, [...] standing on one leg in a 2-legged zone" and many other similarly humorous offenses (160-161). Clearly, there are many laws restricting behavior in this society, yet there are no official police force enforcing the laws. Instead, escaped convicts, like Monster, are hunted by the Hunters, who seek a bounty. When they find Monster's dead body, the First Hunter says "If you think yll get any of the reward money, you got another thing coming" (220). In this anarchical society with oppressive laws, abortion is legal and morally reprehensible. Hester's murder of her son is a delayed abortion, which is foreshadowed by her occupation. Trapped as the necessary murderer of unwanted children, Hester is forced to kill her criminal son.

The endings of Parks' plays depict the inevitable result of characters that must inhabit oppressive Black identities. Death overshadows both *Topdog* and *Fucking A* from the beginning. Indeed, *Mule* and *Raisin* also refer to death, but they do not depict it. "Brazzle's ole yaller mule," of which the mule bone originated, died four years prior to the play (Hughes and Hurston 53). In *Raisin*, Mr. Younger, the grandfather of the family, dies before the play begins. Death is present in the modernist plays, but does not overshadow the action in the same way the inevitable deaths overshadow Parks' plays. In Postmodernism, the deaths are not necessarily pessimistic endings, but an inevitable, predictable, and satisfying. Death is the "absolute limit" for fiction (McHale

232). With few exceptions, fiction and theatre do not explore anything beyond death. The main characters do not die in the endings, but their futures are less predictable and directed as the characters' in *Mule* and *Raisin*. The audience has no spatial, temporal, or social context for Parks' characters and cannot predict the future as they can in the earlier plays' specified settings.

Death by murder is the only action available to the Black postmodern characters who attempt to free themselves from exploitative functions, but remain liminal. As oppressive hard labor or being a sexual object, *Topdog* and *Fucking A* show that death is the result of their liminal functions: Booth as 3-card monte dealer and Hester as abortionist. While the meaning produced by the signifiers of character and language in Parks' postmodern plays are ambiguous. They can only exist within the postmodern space and offer many possible signified meanings. Parks' postmodern plays especially rely on "linguistic sludge" in order to depict the characters' identities. However, the "linguistic sludge" is not gibberish. Gibberish is senseless; the pater and patois signify a liminal identity. Indeed, the focus on the signifier creates ambiguity and potential different readings, but ambiguity is welcome to theatre artists who desire to take a text from a playwright, interpret a possible meaning and imbue it with their own interpretation. Ambiguity in theatre allows for diverse productions. Productions of American realist plays often resemble each other, a symptom of the specific settings like those in *Mule Bone* and *A Raisin in the Sun*. Productions of postmodern plays, like *Fucking A* and *Topdog/Underdog* open the potential for creativity for theatre artists because the playwright leaves what McHale refers to as "an internal space within the sign" (McHale 56). This internal space available to actors, directors, and designers in postmodern theatre allows for greater creativity and wider interpretation than are available in American Realism.

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